

Virtue Ethics

Introduction to Philosophy

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Virtue Ethics

What Is Virtue Ethics?

- Developed by Aristotle in the **Nicomachean Ethics**
- Focuses on **character** rather than rules or consequences
- Central question: What kind of person should I be?
- A **virtue** is a stable disposition to feel and act well

- Contrast with deontology (rules) and consequentialism (outcomes).
- Aristotle asks: what kind of person should I be?
- Virtue ethics is agent-centered, not act-centered.

The Virtues and the Mean

- Virtues are the **mean** between two vices (excess and deficiency)
- Example: courage lies between **cowardice** (deficiency) and **recklessness** (excess)
- The mean is relative to the person and circumstances
- **Phronesis** (practical wisdom) guides us to the right mean

- Give examples: courage is the mean between cowardice and recklessness.
- The mean is relative to the person and situation — not a mathematical midpoint.
- Phronesis (practical wisdom) is the master virtue that guides the others.

Eudaimonia: The Good Life

- The goal of a virtuous life is **eudaimonia** — human flourishing
- Not mere pleasure or wealth, but living and doing well as a human being
- Eudaimonia is an **activity** of the soul in accordance with virtue
- Requires a complete life — not achievable in a single moment

- Eudaimonia is often translated “happiness” but “flourishing” is more accurate.
- It is an activity, not a feeling — you can’t be eudaimon in a moment.
- Raises the question: can virtuous people suffer misfortune and still flourish?

Virtue vs. Vice: Examples

Deficiency	Excess
Cowardice	Recklessness
Miserliness	Profligacy
Insensibility	Self-indulgence
Understatement	Boastfulness

- Walk through each row and ask students to identify the virtuous mean.
- Emphasize that the mean is situational, not a fixed rule.

Can virtue be taught?

- Pause here before moving on.
- Aristotle's answer: yes, but only through practice and habituation, not instruction alone.



- Aristotle, 384–322 BCE.
- Student of Plato; tutor of Alexander the Great.
- Founded the Lyceum in Athens.